

Why Note-Taking and Summarizing Are Better Than Re-Reading

A study skills explanation based on Unit 6 — for S4 Associate Nurses students

1. The Problem with Re-Reading

Unit 6 of the S4 English textbook teaches you effective study strategies. One of the most important lessons is that re-reading is one of the least effective ways to study — even though it feels productive.

When you re-read, your brain recognises familiar words and this creates a feeling of mastery. But recognition is NOT the same as understanding. Re-reading is a passive activity: your brain is not working hard enough to store information in long-term memory. As a result, the information fades quickly.

Note-taking and summarizing are active strategies. They force your brain to process, organise, and express ideas — which is how real learning happens.

Re-Reading (Passive)	Note-Taking / Summarizing (Active)
Eyes scan the page again passively	You rewrite ideas in your own words
Words feel familiar — creates illusion of knowledge	Brain makes new connections actively
Brain stays passive, no deep processing	Forces you to identify what is important
Information fades quickly after the test	Strengthens long-term memory
Wastes time covering the same ground	Notes become a tool you can use again
Does NOT build real understanding	Builds REAL understanding

2. The Science: Why Active Learning Works

Unit 6 trains you to work with language — not just look at it. This reflects an important truth about how the human brain learns:

BRAIN SCIENCE

The Encoding Principle

Your brain remembers information better when it is connected to something you DID, not just something you SAW. Writing a note or a summary forces your brain to retrieve, process, and reconstruct meaning — exactly the kind of work that builds lasting memory.

UNIT 6 CONNECTION

Reading and Understanding in Unit 6

Unit 6 asks you to read extracts from literature and interpret instructions.

To do this well, you must identify key information, organise it, and express it clearly.

These are core note-taking and summarizing skills. Simply re-reading would not help you answer comprehension questions or complete the unit's activities.

3. What Good Note-Taking Looks Like

Based on the study skills approach of Unit 6, good note-taking follows these steps:

1. **Read the whole text first.** Get the overall meaning before writing anything. This is called reading for gist.
2. **Find the main idea of each paragraph.** Every good paragraph has a topic sentence. Find it and write it in your own words.
3. **Write key words and phrases — NOT full sentences.** Use abbreviations, symbols (→, =, &), and your own shorthand. Copying full sentences is re-writing, not note-taking.
4. **Organise notes under headings.** Unit 6 stresses the importance of headings and subheadings. Apply the same structure to your own notes.
5. **Review without looking at the text.** Close the book. If you can explain the content using only your notes, you have truly understood it.

4. Summary Writing: Notes in Full Sentences

A summary is different from notes. It is a shortened version of the original text, written in full sentences and in your own words. Unit 6 links this to the Standard Paragraph structure taught throughout the textbook.

A good summary must:

- Include only the most important ideas from the text
- Be significantly shorter than the original
- Use your own words — never copied phrases
- Follow the original order of ideas
- Not include your personal opinion

WORKED EXAMPLE — FROM UNIT 6 CONTEXT

Original text (Group work passage)

"Working in groups enables students to share ideas and develop critical thinking. Each member brings different knowledge and perspectives to the group. When students discuss and question each other's ideas, their understanding deepens. Group work also builds communication skills important in nursing careers."

NOTE-TAKING VERSION

Short-form notes

Group work: shares ideas → deepens understanding

Builds communication skills → useful in nursing

SUMMARY VERSION

Full summary (2 sentences)

Group work improves students' thinking and understanding by combining different perspectives through discussion. It also develops the communication skills needed in professional fields like nursing.

5. Study Skill Tips from Unit 6

Unit 6 teaches school language functions — academic phrases and structures used in formal writing and study. These are tools that make your note-taking more precise:

- Use topic sentences: The first sentence of each paragraph usually contains the main idea. Find it; note it.
- Label your notes: Use headings from the original text — just as Unit 6 teaches about subheadings in writing.
- Be concise: Remove all examples, repeated ideas, and filler words. Keep only the core meaning.
- Use linking words: Unit 6 covers connectives. Use them in summaries: 'therefore', 'however', 'as a result'.
- Review after class: Within 24 hours, review your notes while the lesson is still fresh.
- Work in groups: Unit 6 covers group work specifically. Compare notes with classmates to fill gaps.

6. Key Vocabulary from Unit 6

These terms from Unit 6's vocabulary section relate directly to note-taking and summarizing:

Term	Definition	How it relates to note-taking
Summary	A short account giving the main points	The goal — distil, keep only what matters
Extract	A short passage taken from a longer	Unit 6 uses extracts as note-taking practice

	text	
Heading	A title introducing a section of text	Use headings to organise your own notes clearly
Interpret	To understand and explain the meaning	Notes interpret — they don't copy, they explain
Concise	Giving much info clearly in few words	Notes must be concise — long notes defeat the purpose
Paraphrase	To express meaning using different words	Core skill in both note-taking and summarizing

Conclusion

Re-reading feels comfortable because familiar words create an illusion of knowledge. But Unit 6 — and the science of learning — shows that real understanding only comes through active engagement: taking notes, writing summaries, and expressing ideas in your own words.

Every time you take notes instead of re-reading, you are building a stronger, more lasting understanding — not just for your English exam, but for your future career as an associate nurse, where understanding instructions and communicating clearly are essential skills.